
GOLDEN MAPLE LANDSCAPING

· 2026 EDITION ·

The 2026 Simcoe County Backyard *Cost Guide.*

Planning ranges for early budget conversations.
Confirm current scope and pricing for your project.

BARRIE · INNISFIL · ORO-MEDONTE · SPRINGWATER

A guide written *for the homeowner.*

If you're reading this, you're probably somewhere between Pinterest boards and a panic attack about the price tag. You've likely gathered two or three quotes that swing wildly — one says \$18,000, another says \$42,000 — and nobody seems willing to explain why.

I built this guide because that's broken. You shouldn't have to learn the hardscape industry from the inside before you can confidently choose who puts a five-figure investment into your yard. This guide is a planning resource: it uses illustrative price ranges and scope examples to help you prepare questions for a contractor. It is not a record of completed projects, a quote, or a promise of a particular result.

My philosophy is simple. Premium landscaping isn't decoration. It's engineering. The pavers you see are the easy part; excavation, drainage, aggregate, soil conditions, and site access can all affect the work below them. Final construction details must be set for the specific site and documented in the written scope.

Read it cover to cover or skim the tables. Either way, you'll walk into your next contractor conversation knowing exactly what questions to ask and what numbers should look right. That's the goal.

Yorkis Estevez

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What a backyard *actually costs.*

Most homeowners over-shoot or under-shoot their budget by 40%. These four tiers describe what's realistic for a fully-engineered, premium-built outdoor space in Simcoe County in 2026.

I. Front Entrance Makeover **\$15,000 — \$35,000+**

Removal of builder-grade steps, new concrete foundation, custom stone steps, and an interlocking walkway to the driveway. The upper end adds low-voltage LED lighting, planting beds, and premium natural stone components.

II. The Functional Backyard — Patio & Fire Pit **\$25,000 — \$50,000+**

A 400–600 sqft interlocking patio with site-specific base preparation, a built-in seating wall, and a custom fire feature (wood-burning or natural gas). This is the most common starting point — enough scope to host without overshooting.

III. Elevated Outdoor Living Space **\$60,000 — \$120,000+**

Multiple zones: dining, lounging, gas fire feature. Custom outdoor kitchen (BBQ, fridge, granite counters), structural retaining walls if the yard is sloped, and full landscape lighting. Effectively adds a new room to the home.

IV. Complete Property Transformation **\$150,000 — \$300,000+**

Whole-property scope: front driveway, entrance, extensive grading and drainage solutions, multi-level backyard terraces, pool surrounds, and fully automated lighting and irrigation systems.

Six common projects, *by the numbers.*

Illustrative 2026 planning ranges for interlocking project scopes in Simcoe County. They are not quotes and may change with site access, materials, drainage, design, and the written scope of work.

Project Type	Typical Size	2026 Range
Backyard patio	150–300 sqft	\$9,000 — \$18,000
Large patio with features	300–600 sqft	\$18,000 — \$40,000
Front walkway	50–120 sqft	\$4,000 — \$9,000
Single driveway	400–600 sqft	\$20,000 — \$35,000
Double driveway	600–900 sqft	\$30,000 — \$50,000
Pool surround	200–500 sqft	\$15,000 — \$35,000

◆ PER-SQUARE-FOOT BENCHMARK

The **\$55–\$85 per square foot** figure is an illustrative planning benchmark from this guide, not a quote or a universal construction standard. Compare written scope, materials, drainage, and site conditions rather than relying on a price alone.

Why the wide ranges? Site access, base depth, paver choice, and whether your yard is flat or sloped can move the final price. The next pages outline questions to use when comparing written scopes.

The material cost ladder.

Pavers are the single biggest material line on a patio quote. Here's what each tier of paver actually costs per square foot — and what you give up going down-market.

Material	2026 Price	Best Use
Standard concrete pavers	\$45 — \$60/sqft	Budget patios and walkways. Builder-grade colour and finish — fades within 2–3 years.
Techo-Bloc premium	\$60 — \$80/sqft	Mid-to-high patios and driveways. Lifetime transferable warranty engineered for Ontario freeze-thaw.
Porcelain pavers	\$75 — \$100/sqft	Modern outdoor living and pool decks. Specialized lifting equipment + flawless base required.
Natural stone	\$80 — \$120/sqft	High-end feature areas, steps, and vertical detail. Each stone unique.

◆ OUR RECOMMENDATION

For 90% of Simcoe County patios, **Techo-Bloc** or **Permacon** hits the right balance — premium colour mixes that don't fade, lifetime transferable warranty, and engineering specifically tuned for Ontario freeze-thaw cycles. Skip the builder-grade tier unless you genuinely don't care about the patio in 5 years.

Three patios, *three budgets.*

Same 400 sqft footprint, three very different builds. This is how the decisions compound when you choose materials, edges, and features.

FUNCTIONAL	ENTERTAINER	LUXURY
≈ \$15,000	≈ \$25,000	\$40,000+
The Minimum	The Sweet Spot	Outdoor Room
Standard pavers, simple square shape, flat yard with good access. Base and drainage details are confirmed for the specific site.	Techo-Bloc / Unilock Beacon Hill premium pavers, contrasting border, curved edges, matching stone fire pit. Where most homeowners land.	Large-format premium slabs, slight slope with seating wall, integrated LED lighting, built-in natural-gas fire feature. Hosts dinner parties.

A worked example.

An illustrative example of how a backyard scope can be priced; it is not a completed-project record or quote.

Line Item	Calculation	Cost
350 sqft Techo-Bloc patio	350 × \$70/sqft installed	\$24,500
3 stone steps (front of patio)	Custom-cut, mortared	\$2,500
Low-voltage LED landscape lighting	10 fixtures + transformer	\$3,000
TOTAL	Premium turn-key install	≈ \$30,000

What actually moves *the number.*

Eight variables explain why two patios of identical size can quote \$14K apart. Knowing them lets you compare apples to apples.

Base preparation	Excavation, aggregate, bedding, compaction, drainage, soil, and final depth are project-specific. Ask the contractor to document the proposed base design and site assumptions in the written scope.
Geotextile & geogrid	Geotextile separates clay soil from the stone base (mandatory on most Simcoe County yards). Geogrid ties retaining walls into the earth. Skipping them is the #1 reason walls lean by 18 months.
Sloped lot premium	If your yard slopes, expect +15–25% on the base price for extra excavation, retaining, and stepped designs. South Barrie clay slopes are particularly demanding.
Restricted access	A 3-foot side gate turns a 4-day install into a 9-day install. Material moves by hand or mini-excavator instead of skid-steer. Labour cost can double on the same square footage.
Steps	\$1,500 — \$4,000 per set , depending on stone type, custom cuts, and whether they're free-standing or mortared into a foundation.
Built-in lighting	\$2,000 — \$5,000 for In-Lite or Kichler LED systems including fixtures, wiring, transformer, and timers. Done right, transforms how the space reads at night.
Seat walls	\$3,000 — \$8,000 for a built-in seat wall with cap stones. Adds permanent seating without consuming patio square footage.
Romex jointing premium	Polymer-infused jointing (vs. standard polymeric sand) adds \$3–5/sqft but eliminates ant-pulling, weed germination, and joint washout. Worth it in shaded yards.
Perimeter retaining wall	A 2-foot retaining wall around a sloped patio adds \$5,000 — \$10,000 . Often necessary in Oro-Medonte and Springwater builds where natural grade falls.

If not interlocking, *then what?*

How interlocking pavers stack up against the four most common alternatives in Simcoe County. Lifespan and maintenance assume Ontario freeze-thaw conditions.

Material	Price/sqft	Lifespan	Maintenance
Interlocking stone	\$55 — \$85	25 — 30 yrs	Low
Stamped concrete	\$20 — \$35	10 — 15 yrs	Medium (will crack)
Poured concrete	\$15 — \$25	15 — 20 yrs	Low
Natural flagstone	\$40 — \$70	30+ yrs	Low
Wood deck	\$35 — \$65	15 — 20 yrs	High (annual stain)

■ THE HIDDEN TRUTH ABOUT STAMPED CONCRETE

Stamped concrete is *not* a question of **if** it cracks, only **when**. Ontario's freeze-thaw cycles guarantee it. Interlocking pavers **flex** with the freeze-thaw — individual pavers move slightly, the patio stays intact. That's the whole reason interlocking became the regional standard.

The five hidden costs *in a low quote.*

When quotes differ substantially, compare the written scope before choosing. The following items are questions to review, not assumptions about another contractor's work.

01

Base design

Ask for the proposed excavation, aggregate, bedding, compaction, drainage, and site assumptions in writing. A final base design should be project-specific.

02

Skipped geotextile & geogrid

Geotextile fabric separates clay from stone. Geogrid ties retaining walls into the earth. Both cost money and time — both get cut. Result: patios that pump clay up through the joints, walls that lean at 18 months.

03

Poor drainage planning

A real install includes 1.5–2% slope, perforated drain tiles, and water-flow assessment. Cheap installs trap water against your foundation (flooded basements) or pond it on the surface (frozen pavers, cracked stone).

04

Bait-and-switch materials

The quote says 'premium pavers.' The truck arrives with builder-grade product from a big-box store. Same shape — different mix, different finish, fades in two seasons. Always demand the exact brand and line in writing.

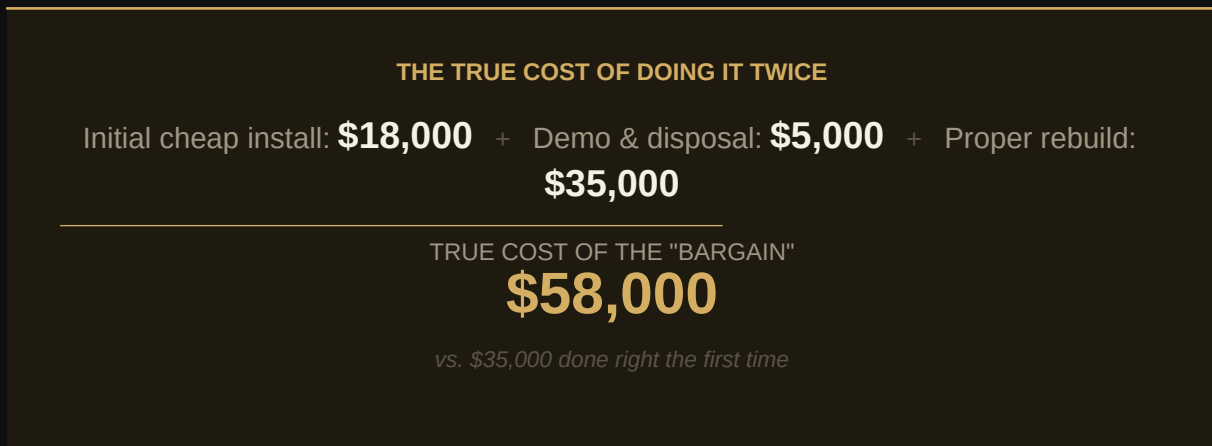
05

No WSIB, no liability insurance

Premium contractors carry WSIB (\$) and multimillion-dollar liability (\$\$). The unmarked truck doing it cash for \$18K? Often neither. If a worker injures themselves on your property, **you can be held personally liable** for their medical bills and lost wages.

The true cost *of the bargain.*

This illustrative comparison shows why a complete written scope matters. Actual costs, conditions, remedies, and project outcomes vary and require a site review.



"Use a written scope to compare what is included, excluded, and confirmed for your site."

— YORKIS ESTEVEZ, FOUNDER

Red flags & *the four questions.*

Six red flags in a quote.

- ✗ Per-sqft prices under \$40 installed
- ✗ No mention of base depth or aggregate type
- ✗ "We'll figure it out on site"
- ✗ No written multi-year warranty
- ✗ Deposit requested over 50% upfront
- ✗ No proof of WSIB clearance or liability insurance

Standard deposit structure is 10–30% upfront, balance in milestone payments tied to base completion, paver delivery, and final cleanup.

Four questions.

In writing, before you sign.

- Q1.** Exactly how many inches deep will you excavate for the base?
- Q2.** Are you using 3/4" clear stone or limestone screenings ("gravel dust") for the base?
- Q3.** Can you provide a current WSIB clearance certificate today?
- Q4.** Does your contract include a written multi-year warranty covering sinking and settlement?

If the answer to any of these is hesitation, vagueness, or a subject change — walk.

◆ THE YORKIS RULE

Use the answers to compare written scopes. Base depth, materials, drainage, coverage documents, and workmanship terms should be confirmed for the project.

When to build, *what to budget.*

Build season timing.

Simcoe County's hardscape season runs **April through November**. Premium contractors fill their April–June slots by February. If you want first-half-of-season install for 2026, the smart booking window is:

Jan — Mar: Design phase, material selection, contract signed. Lock April–May install.

Apr — May: Early-season install. Best weather window, highest contractor availability.

Jun — Aug: Peak season. Premium crews at full capacity. Project lead times stretch to 6–10 weeks.

Sep — Nov: Late-season install. Cooler temperatures are actually ideal for paver setting and joint stabilization.

How much to budget.

The **Appraisal Institute of Canada** recommends budgeting **10–15% of your home's total value** for a complete landscape renovation. For a \$900K Barrie home, that's \$90K–\$135K range — which lines up almost exactly with our Tier III "Elevated Outdoor Living" budget.

Most homeowners under-budget on first-time projects by 25–40% because they price only the patio, forgetting drainage, lighting, plantings, and finishing. Multiply your patio quote by 1.4 for a realistic total.

◆ CONSULTATION & DESIGN SCOPE

Contact us to confirm the current consultation and design scope, including any fees, deliverables, availability, and whether any credit applies to your project.

GOLDEN MAPLE LANDSCAPING

Ready to talk about your *project?*

Contact us to confirm the current consultation and design scope.
Project details are confirmed in the written scope.

CALL	EMAIL	WEB
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◆ WSIB: ASK FOR DOCUMENTATION

◆ COVERAGE: ASK FOR
DOCUMENTATION

◆ WORKMANSHIP: ASK FOR WRITTEN
TERMS

Prices reflect 2026 Simcoe County market and assume premium materials, engineered base preparation, and full-service installation.
All projects subject to final scope and site assessment.

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